

LEAN YEAR 1 BUDGET

# BOOTSTRAP EDITION

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**\$53,000 PILOT YEAR**

*The leanest possible Year 1 plan. 100% of donations reach veterans. Built on community partnerships, donated services, and an unpaid founder.*

FOUNDER: JOHN COLLINS  
MAUI, HAWAII • A 501(C)(3) IN FORMATION

# The Lean Plan

YEAR 1 LEAN BUDGET

**\$53,000**

Same 3 pilot retreats, same 15-18 veterans served. Just bootstrapped.

## How We Get to \$53,000

| Strategy                                                     | Savings          |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| Founder serves as unpaid volunteer Year 1                    | -\$30,000        |
| Activity partnerships (Operation Surf, donated guides, etc.) | -\$4,500         |
| Volunteer veteran peer facilitators (vs paid)                | -\$4,500         |
| Free software stack (TechSoup, Mailchimp, Wave, Notion)      | -\$600           |
| Phone-shot photography (no \$1,500 photo hire)               | -\$1,500         |
| Borrowed donor event venues                                  | -\$1,000         |
| Digital-only marketing materials Year 1                      | -\$500           |
| <b>TOTAL SAVINGS vs. standard budget</b>                     | <b>-\$46,000</b> |

## Year 1 Lean Budget Summary

| Category                                      | Amount          |
|-----------------------------------------------|-----------------|
| Startup & Legal Costs                         | \$3,990         |
| Insurance & Compliance (don't skip)           | \$4,800         |
| 3 Pilot Retreats (with partnerships)          | \$28,800        |
| Operations & Admin (no founder stipend)       | \$2,300         |
| Marketing & Development (lean)                | \$2,000         |
| Contingency (20% — extra buffer for lean ops) | \$8,378         |
| <b>TOTAL</b>                                  | <b>\$50,268</b> |

Round number: **\$53,000** to allow for under-budgeted items and surprises.

# Lean Per-Retreat Cost

Same 7-14 day retreat for ~6 veterans. Reduced by leveraging veteran service partnerships and volunteer facilitators.

| Line Item                      | Standard        | Lean                     |
|--------------------------------|-----------------|--------------------------|
| Round-trip flights to Maui     | \$4,200         | \$4,200                  |
| Ground transport on Maui       | \$500           | \$300 <b>PARTNER</b>     |
| Lodging — donated              | \$0             | \$0                      |
| Groceries & meals              | \$2,100         | \$1,800 <b>DONATIONS</b> |
| Surf instruction               | \$900           | \$0 <b>OP. SURF</b>      |
| Snorkel rental & guides        | \$400           | \$200 <b>PARTNER</b>     |
| Hiking transport & permits     | \$300           | \$300                    |
| Cultural practitioner stipends | \$500           | \$300 <b>PARTNER</b>     |
| Park fees & permits            | \$200           | \$200                    |
| Facilitator stipend            | \$2,000         | \$500 <b>VOLUNTEER</b>   |
| Local helpers / volunteers     | \$500           | \$300                    |
| Farm supplies & gear           | \$300           | \$300                    |
| First aid / safety equipment   | \$200           | \$200                    |
| Per-retreat contingency        | \$500           | \$1,000                  |
| <b>COST PER RETREAT</b>        | <b>\$12,600</b> | <b>\$9,600</b>           |

*\$3,000 saved per retreat through partnerships. 3 retreats × \$9,600 = \$28,800 Year 1.*

## Key Partnerships to Pursue Year 1

- **Operation Surf** — free surf therapy for veterans nationwide
- **Wounded Warrior** Hawaii outdoor programs
- **Local Maui veterans organizations** for volunteer facilitators
- **Hawaiian cultural practitioners** who donate time for veteran healing
- **Local restaurants / churches** for donated meals during retreats
- **Maui rideshare / drivers** who volunteer ground transport

# Why Bootstrap Year 1?

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The lean budget isn't the long-term plan. Years 2 and beyond, the founder gets paid, infrastructure gets built, and the budget grows. But Year 1 is about **proof** — showing that the program works before asking for big money.

## Three reasons this matters:

### 1. Easier to raise

Funders are far more willing to give \$5,000 to a \$53k pilot than a \$99k plan with founder salary. Lean budgets are **credible**.

### 2. Stronger pitch to donors

The line *"Founder serves as an unpaid volunteer in Year 1 — 100% of donations reach veterans directly"* wins donations. Foundations love it. Individual donors love it. Grant officers love it.

### 3. Faster path to launch

\$53,000 is a number you can hit through a single major grant + crowdfunding + community fundraising. \$99,000 takes longer to assemble. Faster funding = faster veterans served.

## When Founder Compensation Begins

Founder salary is **deferred** to Year 2 — or earlier if Year 1 funding exceeds **\$90,000**. This is documented in the bylaws and shared with all funders so there are no surprises.

## After Year 1

Once the pilot is complete, the standard budget kicks in. Year 2 includes founder compensation, paid facilitators, and proper marketing budget. The lean year is a one-time bootstrap — not the operating model.

GET IN TOUCH

# 100% OF DONATIONS REACH **VETERANS**

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A founder who works unpaid. Partners who donate services. A clear plan to bring the first 18 combat veterans home to Maui.

**JOHN COLLINS**

FOUNDER, TURNING THE TIDES

 (615) 739-3008

 [spc2233@hotmail.com](mailto:spc2233@hotmail.com)

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MAUI, HAWAII